

Chillin' with Caramello

Anush Agarwalla and his horse, Sir Caramello Old, is enjoying a **well-deserved break** ahead of the Paris Games, after becoming the first Indian to secure an Olympic spot in dressage.

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With a little less than four months to go until the Paris Olympics, Anush Agarwalla (who, earlier this year, became the first Indian to win a quota in dressage), is on a break.

To be a bit more precise, his horse is. The 25-year-old and his horse — Sir Caramello Old — last competed at the Mechelen Grand Prix in December last year, where he all but assured himself a place at the Paris Games. He was allotted the quota on the basis of his performance in four FEI (Fédération Equestre Internationale) events — Wroclaw (73.485%), Kronenberg (74.4%), Frankfurt (72.9%), and finally Mechelen (74.2%).

Although technically the quota belongs to India, it is a certain guarantee that Agarwalla will be riding at the Olympics. "Officially, others from India can still try to compete until June 24 (when the ranking period for the Olympics closes) but no one else has matched the MER (Minimum Eligibility Rule) to

be eligible for the same," he says.

It helps that there's no one breathing down his neck. That's allowed Anush and his horse to extend their break longer than originally planned. The two were supposed to compete at the Aachen Grand Prix in the last week of March but will now resume their season only at the CDI Hagen this month end.

While Anush, who won a historic bronze for India in dressage at the Asian Games last year, was ready to go, he says he realised that his horse needed to rest a little bit longer.

"He competed a lot in November and December, which was when we actually got our quota. It was a very intensive period for him due to all the competitions. And so I decided to give him a bit more rest until April, because our goal is to be at our peak during the Paris Olympics," he says.

Many of the world's elite and potential rivals for Agarwalla at Paris will be riding in Aachen. In a 20-by-60 metre arena that's

bordered by a low rail, the horses and their riders will show their paces — walk, trot and canter — and be judged according to their smoothness in transition.

Sir Caramello on the other hand will be at Agarwalla's training base at Borchten, Germany, where the pressure will be a lot less. "Although my horse is on vacation, it isn't that he's just going to sit in his stable all day. He is still being ridden a little bit, just like an athlete on active rest. Of course, the intensity of my training session with him is very less and the program is very different. The goal of the training is to just keep him very loose and happy," says Agarwalla.

Instead of the dressage arena, Agarwalla says he'll take Sir Caramello on light rides. "It will be a lot less stressful than preparing for a competition. We'll go hacking (cross country rides) in the forest and the woods. For a horse, that's a bit like going on a holiday. He loves raspberries so he'll eat a lot of that too. Horses find relaxation in